Istanbul Travel Guide

Where Europe meets Asia across the Bosphorus - Turkey

Istanbul: Overview and History

Istanbul is the largest city in Turkey and the only major city in the world that spans two continents, Europe and Asia. The two sides are separated by the Bosphorus strait, which links the Black Sea with the Sea of Marmara.

The city was founded by Greek colonists as Byzantium. In AD 330 the Roman Emperor Constantine made it the new capital of the Roman Empire and named it Constantinople. For more than a thousand years it was the capital of the Eastern Roman, or Byzantine, Empire, linking its history closely with Rome.

In 1453 the Ottoman Sultan Mehmed II conquered Constantinople, and the city became the capital of the Ottoman Empire. The sultans built magnificent mosques, palaces and bazaars. After the Republic of Turkey was founded in 1923, the capital moved to Ankara, but Istanbul remained the country's economic and cultural heart.

The historic areas of Istanbul are a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

Istanbul: Top Attractions

Hagia Sophia was completed in AD 537 under the Byzantine Emperor Justinian. It was a cathedral for nearly a thousand years, then a mosque, then a museum, and is now a mosque again. Its enormous dome and golden mosaics are breathtaking.

Facing it, the Blue Mosque, officially the Sultan Ahmed Mosque, was finished in 1616 and has six minarets and walls covered in blue Iznik tiles. Topkapi Palace was the home of the Ottoman sultans for about 400 years and displays treasures such as the Topkapi Dagger.

The Grand Bazaar is one of the oldest and largest covered markets in the world, with around 4,000 shops selling carpets, lamps, jewellery and ceramics. The Spice Bazaar near Eminonu is full of the scents of spices, teas and Turkish delight.

The Basilica Cistern is a vast underground water reservoir with hundreds of columns, built in the sixth century. Galata Tower offers panoramic views, and a cruise on the Bosphorus passes palaces such as Dolmabahce Palace and wooden mansions along the shore.

Istanbul: Neighborhoods and Food

Sultanahmet is the historic old city with Hagia Sophia, the Blue Mosque and Topkapi Palace. Across the Golden Horn, Beyoglu is the modern heart of the city, centred on the busy pedestrian Istiklal Avenue and its historic red tram. Karakoy, by the water, is full of cafes and galleries.

On the Asian side, Kadikoy has a lively food market and a relaxed local atmosphere; it is reached by a short ferry ride. Balat is a colourful historic neighbourhood with steep streets and painted houses.

Istanbul is a paradise for street food. Simit is a ring of bread covered in sesame seeds, sold from red carts on every corner. Balik ekmek is a grilled fish sandwich served from boats at Eminonu. Doner kebab, lahmacun and many kinds of kebab are everywhere.

In restaurants, start with meze, small dishes such as hummus and stuffed vine leaves. For dessert, try baklava and Turkish delight (lokum). Turkish tea (cay) is served in small tulip-shaped glasses, and Turkish coffee is thick and strong.

Istanbul: Getting Around and Practical Tips

Buy an Istanbulkart, a rechargeable card used on trams, metro, buses, funiculars and ferries. The T1 tram connects Sultanahmet with Eminonu and Karakoy. The Marmaray rail tunnel runs under the Bosphorus between Europe and Asia, and public ferries are a cheap and beautiful way to cross.

Istanbul Airport (IST) is one of the largest airports in the world and the main hub of Turkish Airlines, which flies to more countries than any other airline, including direct flights to Rome, London, Paris, Tokyo, Singapore and New York. Sabiha Gokcen Airport (SAW) is on the Asian side.

The currency is the Turkish lira (TRY). Bargaining is normal in the Grand Bazaar but not in shops with fixed prices. When visiting mosques, women should cover their hair, and everyone should cover their shoulders and knees and remove their shoes.

The best time to visit Istanbul is spring, April and May, when the Istanbul Tulip Festival fills parks such as Emirgan Park with flowers, or autumn, September to November. Summers are hot and winters are cool and rainy.

Istanbul: Sample Itinerary and Day Trips

Day 1: Visit Hagia Sophia, the Blue Mosque and the Basilica Cistern in Sultanahmet, then explore Topkapi Palace. Day 2: Shop in the Grand Bazaar and the Spice Bazaar, eat balik ekmek at Eminonu, and take a Bosphorus cruise in the afternoon.

Day 3: Cross the Galata Bridge, climb Galata Tower, walk along Istiklal Avenue, and take the ferry to Kadikoy for dinner on the Asian side.

The Princes' Islands in the Sea of Marmara are a popular day trip by ferry. On Buyukada, the largest island, there are no private cars, so visitors walk or cycle past old wooden mansions. The city of Bursa, the first Ottoman capital, is famous for its green mosque and Iskender kebab.

Many visitors also fly about one hour and fifteen minutes to Cappadocia to see its fairy chimneys and hot-air balloons.